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OCHA oPt's Biases, Methodological Inconsistencies, and Information Dissemination Methods: A Comprehensive Report

Introduction

The United Nations Office for the Coordination of Humanitarian Affairs (OCHA) plays a significant role in documenting humanitarian crises worldwide. However, the practices of their office in Israel, 'OCHA oPt' exhibit systematic bias, methodological inconsistencies, and flawed data collection methods. This report examines OCHA oPt's reporting, its reliance on questionable sources, and its role in shaping international narratives based on distorted information.

1. OCHA's reporting obligations:

According to UN guidelines, OCHA's activities, as an agency operating on its behalf, must adhere to the humanitarian principles of neutrality, impartiality, humanity, and independence. This obligation is anchored in UN General Assembly resolutions (*GARs 46/182*)1991(and 58/114)2004) and is explicitly outlined in the internal guidelines of various humanitarian agencies, including [OCHA's directives](#).

The organization defines these principles and explains that:

"Humanitarian actors must not take sides in hostilities or engage in controversies of a political, racial, religious, or ideological nature," as well as refrain from "making distinctions based on nationality, race, gender, religious beliefs, class, or political opinions."

In this context, the [OCHA Data Responsibility Guidelines](#) explicitly state that organization employees must ensure that the information used is reliable and accurate and that its use is conducted in an ethical and responsible manner.

However, an examination of OCHA's reporting practices in general, and during the 'Swords of Iron' war in particular, clearly reveals a significant bias in the organization's reports in favor of the Palestinian side.

[OCHA oPt reporting is based on clusters and coordination groups](#). They contribute by providing essential information from needs assessments and monitoring.

On one hand, [OCHA guidelines](#) state that the organization's staff have no direct responsibility for the information collected by the coordination groups and how it is gathered. On the other hand, those guidelines stipulate that reporting on humanitarian events should encourage the receipt of information from coordination groups and private entities. Furthermore, in the weekly reports and the dashboard published on [OCHA's websites](#), information received from coordination groups is mentioned as verified information.

2. One-sided Reporting

OCHA oPt has established an extensive data collection and reporting mechanism which is unique compared to other OCHA missions in terms of the volume of reports and granularity of the empirical data that it produces. Many diplomatic and media entities perceive OCHA oPt as the authoritative source of information on the reality on the ground in the Gaza Strip and Judea and Samaria. However, they are unaware of the degree to which OCHA's reports are one-sided and selective. They do not, for example, monitor nor report systematically violence by Palestinians against Israelis civilians and numerous violations by Palestinian armed groups against Palestinians such as the use of human shields, abuse of civilian facilities and obstruction of humanitarian assistance. To date, OCHA has not reported on the existence of a single Hamas tunnel used for terrorism or any launch of a rocket in a densely populated area in Gaza, both being self-evidently war crimes. In contrast, OCHA exclusively reports on actions done by Israel, which are perceived negatively.

3. Use of unverified and politically biased sources

The reliance on sources with questionable credibility further erodes the organization's impartiality. OCHA oPt frequently cites information without specifying its source or underlying methodology, often referring to unspecified "UN assessments". This practice is seen particularly in its weekly (previously daily) reports on Gaza and the West Bank, where reports have repeatedly relied on information from Hamas-controlled institutions, such as the Gaza Ministry of Health and the Government Media Office, without proper verification. Notably, after October 7, 2023, OCHA initially acknowledged Hamas as the source of casualty figures but later removed these attributions, only reinstating them following Israeli intervention.

Additionally, when reporting on conflicts around the world, OCHA does not consider any other entity in conflict zones reliable enough to regularly cite their casualty figures in its reports (for example, in Ukraine, Sudan, Yemen, etc.). [OCHA oPt on the other hand, cites Hamas on a regular basis as a source. By doing so, it grants Hamas, a terrorist organization, credibility.](#)

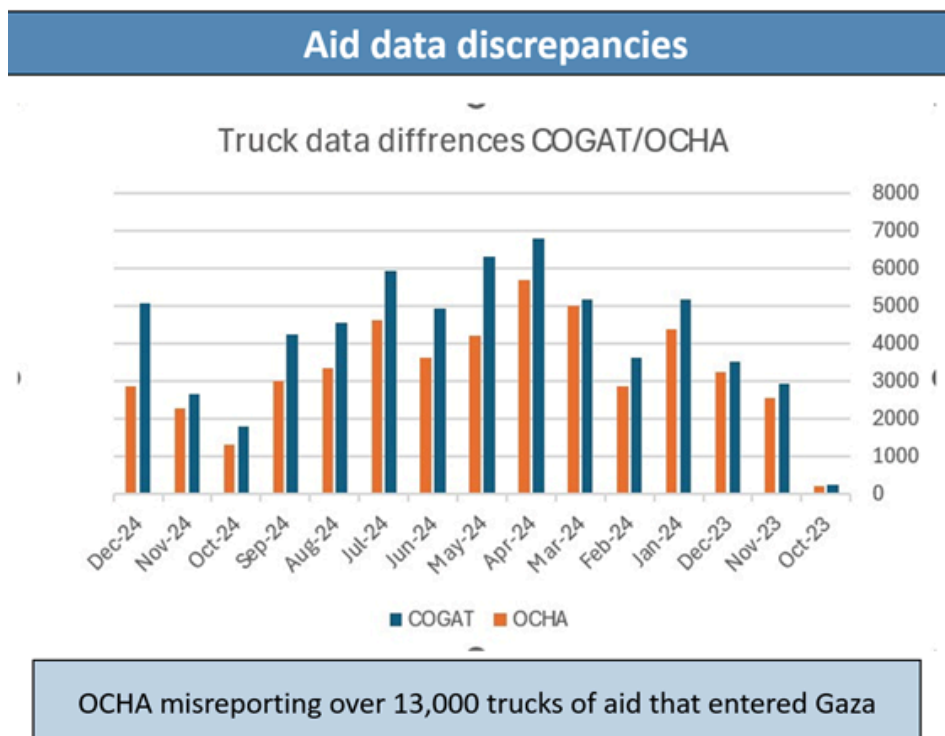
Perhaps most concerning, OCHA does not clearly state that these figures include members of armed groups, contrary to the UN's standard practice elsewhere in the world of distinguishing between civilians and non-civilians in casualty reports—creating the misleading impression that the figures refer only to civilians. The casualty numbers adopted by OCHA oPt also don't account for natural deaths and deaths as a result of internal accuracies inside the Gaza Strip (such as violence between clans and other criminal violence).

Adopting Hamas sources as credible happened gradually over the war, with OCHA oPt reports published in the weeks following October 7 acknowledging the incredibility of Gaza

reports published in the weeks following October 7, acknowledging the inconsistency of Gaza MoH by using the word "reportedly". In later reports, Gaza MoH has been accepted as a fully credible source, with OCHA oPt only using the word "reportedly" for incidents quoted from Gaza open-source media.

4. Humanitarian aid reporting and discrepancies

OCHA only tracks humanitarian goods entering Gaza by the UN and partial information on other INGOs, excluding private sector aid. Despite a disclaimer on OCHA's dashboard stating the above, UN officials, UN publications and others using the data quote the numbers of aid trucks without providing the disclaimer. This leads to a skewed picture of the full amount of aid that entered the Gaza Strip throughout the war, showcasing significantly lower numbers of aid that entered Gaza.

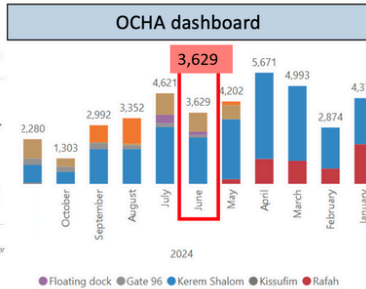
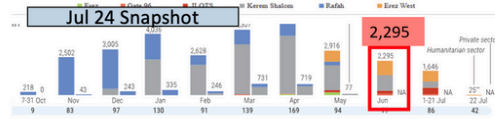
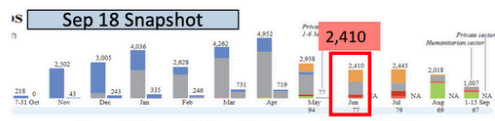
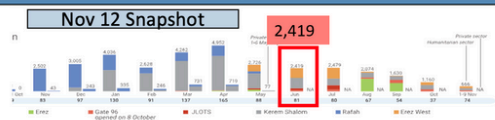


OCHA's counting methods also ignored security-screened goods that were introduced into the Gaza Strip and left uncollected.

Only on April 22, OCHA oPt added an additional disclaimer stating that the aid data is updated upon verification, thus acknowledging that the aid data on the dashboard was not complete. Since the added disclaimer to the dashboard, the information is only updated on the dashboard itself, and not in previous publications, leading those quoting previous reports to base their facts on outdated information.

Humanitarian aid reporting gaps

Aid data discrepancies - June 2024 humanitarian aid truck numbers



Actual number of trucks: 4,938

OCHA misreporting over 13,000 trucks of aid that entered Gaza



Additionally, OCHA made terminology adjustments: changing the term from “incoming trucks” to “collected trucks,” clarifying only UN-monitored aid is counted. Previously, the data lacked context, including the fact that it covers only part of the assistance delivered, fueling international criticism of Israel.

OCHA also does not acknowledge the presence of another (and more extensive) set of data (managed by COGAT) while having no reservations of referring extensively to Hamas-run ministries as information sources. **This selective reporting and lack of transparency have provided governments and officials who relied on OCHA oPt's data set a distorted picture of the overall humanitarian situation and the necessary actions to address it.**

OCHA oPt's reports also contain misleading food insecurity projections. Weekly reports after the hostage release deal began still claimed that 91% of Gaza's population faced extreme food insecurity, based on outdated IPC estimates from [November 2024](#) and despite that fact that hundreds more trucks of food entered Gaza daily. These reports failed to incorporate food aid deliveries post-ceasefire, despite acknowledging the ceasefire itself. [The Israeli government challenged the IPC report's credibility](#), yet OCHA oPt continued citing its figures, fueling misleading famine narratives that misrepresented the situation on the ground.

5. Data washing

Unverified statistics and information are often reported by OCHA oPt without a source or a verification but with the appropriate disclaimer. Other UN organizations, international organizations, and governments quote the original OCHA report, using OCHA as a source. The original disclaimers disappear when other entities quote OCHA's reports and are quoted as verified information by the UN. An example to this would be the claim that Gaza has the “largest population of child amputees in modern history” that has been widely circulated by international organizations based on flawed extrapolations. This misrepresentation further misguides global discourse on the conflict, putting pressure on the government of Israel without any justification.

6. Inadequate acknowledgment of October 7, 2023 atrocities

Despite the extensive documentation of Hamas's atrocities on October 7, OCHA has not published a single report detailing these war crimes. The suffering endured by Israeli society, including due to rocket attacks, extensive displacement and trauma is at best mentioned only in passing. This selective emphasis creates an imbalance that compromises OCHA's humanitarian principles of neutrality and independence.

In light of these concerns. OCHA oPt is expected to take immediate corrective actions

to demonstrate OCHA's commitment to reliable, credible and verified information:

1. Correct Misinformation – Amend inaccurate data and unsubstantiated claims in OCHA reports and statements since October 7, including the omission of Hamas-affiliated sources, as well as correcting previous reports to match the data presented on the OCHA oPt aid dashboard.

2. Clarify Casualty Data – Clearly state that reported fatalities and injuries include members of armed groups and individuals involved in violent attacks against Israelis.

The above steps are not comprehensive, but it highlights some of the key areas requiring attention and correction.

OCHA's credibility as a humanitarian organization depends on its ability to operate without political influence. Addressing these issues is critical for ensuring that its humanitarian efforts genuinely serve all affected populations without bias.

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